



Kiani Crown

△ **Aga Muhammad Khan Qajar**, who created the Kiani Crown in 1796 (shown here around 1820)

A piece of royal regalia like no other, the Kiani crown was the coronation crown in the Persian crown jewels and was used throughout the Qajar dynasty (1796–1925). It was a powerful symbol of royal authority, and is unique in its lavish decoration and for the sheer number of pearls used in its design.

The crown is 32cm (12½in) high without its detachable aigrette (plume), and 19.5cm (7½in) wide. The base of the crown is made from red velvet and is stitched with 1,800 small pearls of 7–9mm (about ¼in) in diameter. Around 300 emeralds decorate the crown, mainly on the aigrette, the



Mohammad Ali Shah Qajar
(1872–1925) with the crown

largest of which is 80 carats; there are also approximately 1,800 rubies and spinels, the largest weighing 120 carats. Numerous diamonds stud the crown, with a 23-carat diamond as the centrepiece.

The Kiani Crown was created by Agha Mohammad Khan, founder of the Qajar dynasty, in 1796 and modified by Fath-Ali

Shah (who reigned from 1797 to 1834), the second of the Qajar kings. Fath-Ali Shah was renowned for his patronage of Persian art, as well as for having 1,000 wives and fathering over 100 children. Five more kings wore the crown at their coronation.

The crown was present, although unworn, at the 1926 coronation of Reza Shah, who seized power in a coup. This brought an end to the Qajar dynasty and the last of the line, Ahmed Shah, fled to Europe. Reza ordered the creation of a new crown, and the Kiani crown became a museum piece.



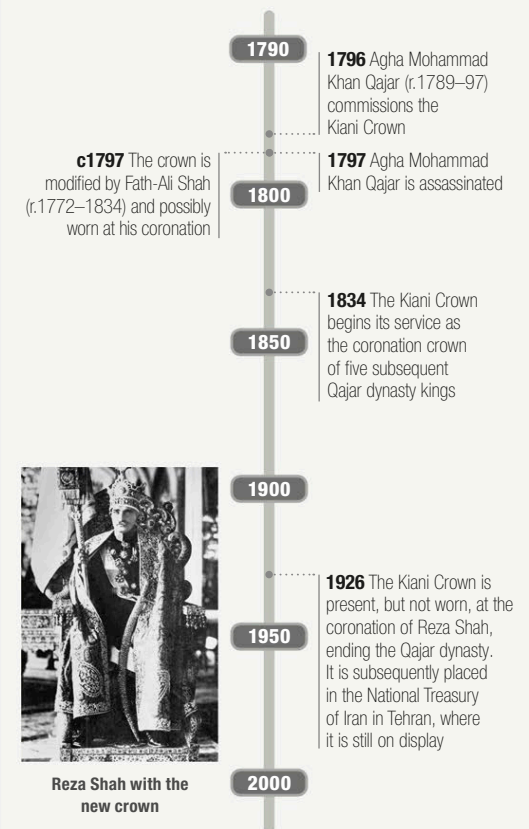
120-carat spinel

23-carat diamond

The Kiani Crown, Persia's symbol of royal and religious power for around 130 years, displayed at the National Treasury, Tehran

Key dates

1796–1926



It was entirely composed... as to form a mixture of the most beautiful colours

R Ker **Porter**
Travel writer, on the crown